

**DEVI PRASAD SHETTY**

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CURING THE SYSTEM

The new government must take up healthcare as a priority on the agenda of its first hundred days of governance to make the sector grow and affordable for all

The world is going through a deep recession. At such a time, one thing we need in abundance is jobs for the semi-skilled and unskilled. This is the only way equal distribution of wealth can take place. The healthcare industry is ideally poised to occupy this position. For instance, a turnover of Rs 1 crore in the IT industry would mean employment for five to seven people while the same turnover in the healthcare industry would employ 250 people. The IT industry hires people from the upper-middle strata and rich families, usually engineers, whereas the healthcare industry hires nurses, to the tune of 80 per cent of the jobs created, from the lower socio-economic strata.

Developing countries require jobs for women as their empowerment helps build confidence in them and their children, who are the building blocks of the nation. So, the agenda for the forthcoming government should be to drive the economy on the fundamentals of growth in the healthcare industry. Global healthcare and wellness is a \$4.5-trillion industry. It is the second largest industry after the agro-industry. Even then, healthcare reaches only 8 per cent of the world's population.

To simplify it, this means India ideally should be performing 25 lakh heart surgeries in a year. But all the hospitals specialising in heart treatment put together are carrying out only 80,000 heart surgeries and the rest gradually perish over a period of time. This is the situation of healthcare today. Policymakers should look at the healthcare industry as not only an industry which addresses pain but also as one which can drive the economy. The last century was driven by machines that

addressed human toil and it is strongly believed that this century will be driven by healthcare.

This, however, will only happen if policymakers make a conscious effort to put the right policies in place soon. I would suggest that the new government must take up healthcare as a priority on the agenda of its first 100 days of governing. Here are six steps that should be implemented without much delay.

First, India trains 36,000 doctors a year, of whom only 10 per cent get an opportunity to become a specialist. Due to this, talented children do not wish to become doctors. Today, the importance of a general practitioner in healthcare delivery is diminishing. Unless a doctor with an MBBS degree acquires additional skills in treating diabetes or the heart or the kidney, he will not be able to make both ends meet. As medical education is very rigidly controlled, these doctors should have a degree which is recognised by the Medical Council of India to qualify for these things. And with the current model of postgraduate training programmes, only 10 per cent of the qualifying doctors can become specialists. All over the world, 100 per cent of the doctors who graduate get the opportunity to become a specialist and they have additional seats to train overseas doctors based on the requirement. In simple terms, we should eliminate the licence raj in higher medical education so that an M.D. Radiology seat is not sold to the highest bidder of Rs 2 crore. If this policy decision is not implemented India will become the country which trains the largest number of MBBS doctors and depends on importing foreign doctors to perform a hysterectomy or a heart operation.

PRESCRIPTION

➤ We should eliminate the licence raj in higher medical education

➤ The government should not look at the industry as an avenue for tax collection

➤ The government should be a health insurance provider, not a healthcare provider